Counters

Contemporary Digital Electronic Systems — Chapter 12

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Why This Chapter Matters

Counters are the simplest and most widely used sequential circuits: every digital clock, timer, frequency divider and sequence generator contains one. They are also the first circuits where the state is read as a number, a bridge from registers to the state-based thinking of Chapters 13–15.

After this chapter, you can:

1. Design asynchronous (ripple) counters of any modulus and explain their limitation.
2. Design synchronous binary up counters.
3. Design a modulo-*N* counter (*N* not a power of two), such as a decade counter, with the synchronous design procedure.
4. Use a counter as a frequency divider.

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An Opening Question

A 50 MHz clock drives an LED that should blink once per second. What is the modulus of the counter between them?

We answer this with the frequency-division property of counters.

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What Is a Counter?

- A series of flip-flops whose outputs form a binary number; each clock pulse increments the count.
- Key difference, the clocking method:
  - Asynchronous (ripple): each stage's output clocks the next; stages change one after another.
  - Synchronous: one common clock; all outputs change together.
- Other classifications: modulus, count direction (up, down, up/down), edge polarity, flip-flop type.
- Modulus (mod) = number of states. n flip-flops give up to 2^n states: a 3-bit counter is mod-8.
- A counter with fewer than 2^n states is truncated: a decade (mod-10) counter counts 0000 to 1001.

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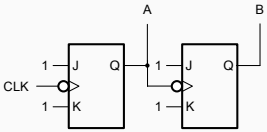
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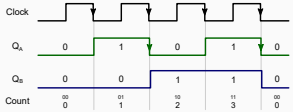
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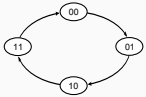
2-Bit Ripple Counter



Clock	Q_B	Q_A
Initial	0	0
1	0	1
2	1	0
3	1	1
4	0	0

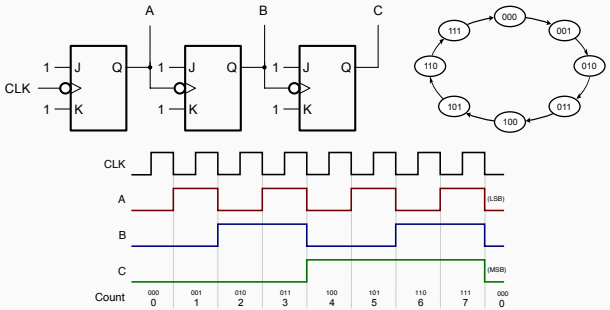
- The external clock drives only flip-flop A. Each falling edge toggles A.
- When A falls from 1 to 0, B toggles.





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3-Bit Ripple Counter



- $2^3 = 8$ states: mod-8.
- Any flip-flop that can toggle works: T, JK with $J = K = 1$, or D with $\overline{Q}$ fed back to D.

Ripple Counters Divide Frequency

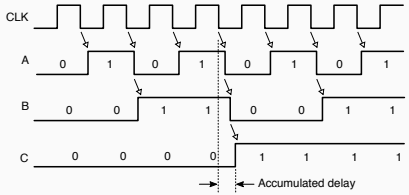
- Each flip-flop divides its clock by 2. With an 8 kHz clock, A, B and C output 4 kHz, 2 kHz and 1 kHz.
- A counter of modulus N divides the input frequency by N (if it cycles through its N states once per period).

An answer to the opening question

50 MHz to 1 Hz needs division by 50 000 000: a counter of modulus 50 000 000 ($\lceil \log_2 50\,000\,000 \rceil = 26$ flip-flops). A divide-by-N counter turns an f Hz clock into f/N Hz.

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Limitation: Cumulative Propagation Delay



- Each stage waits for the previous one, so changes ripple.
- With delay t_p per stage, the output settles about nt_p after the clock edge:

$$T \geq nt_p, \qquad f_{\max} \leq \frac{1}{nt_p}$$

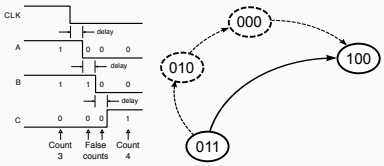
Simplified model: it ignores other timing requirements.

Example: 4-bit counter, $t_p = 12$ ns

$nt_p = 48$ ns, so $f_{\max} \leq 20.8$ MHz. Modulus 16: output at the last stage is about $20.8/16 \approx 1.3$ MHz.

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False (Ghost) States



- Transition 011 $\rightarrow$ 100: A toggles (010), B toggles (000), C toggles (100).
- The intermediate states are temporary results of delay, not part of the sequence.
- They matter if other circuits read the outputs as a number while they are changing. Sample only after settling.

If a ripple counter is used only for frequency division, unused stages may be less restrictive; still check the flip-flop specifications.

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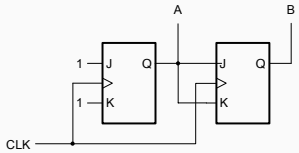
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4 **Synchronous Counters**

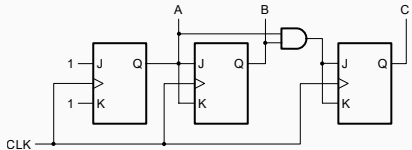
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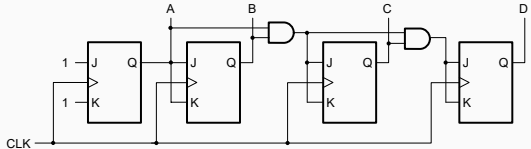
Synchronous Binary Counters



2-bit, mod-4



3-bit, mod-8

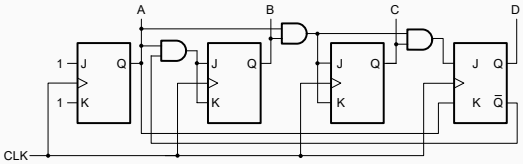


4-bit, mod-16

- One clock for every flip-flop: outputs change together, with no stage-to-stage delay.
- The LSB toggles on every pulse; each higher bit toggles only when all lower bits are 1. Combinational logic (AND gates) detects this.
- Costs extra logic, but runs faster.

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Decade Counter and Speed



Mod-10: counts 0000 to 1001, then 0000

- Four flip-flops could hold 16 states, but this counter uses only ten.
- The longest path is one AND gate plus one flip-flop: $f_{\max} \le 1/(t_g + t_f)$: the delay does not grow with the number of stages (very wide counters need larger AND gates or a gate tree).

Example: $t_f = 12$ ns, $t_g = 5$ ns

$f_{\max} \le 1/17$ ns ≈ 58.8 MHz, about $2.8\times$ the ripple counter's 20.8 MHz.

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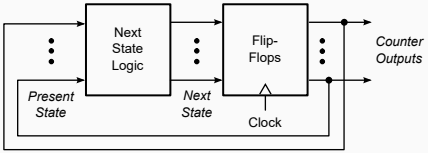
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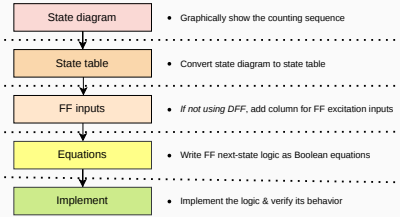
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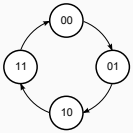
Counter Design Procedure





- A synchronous counter is flip-flops plus next-state logic: the counting sequence is set by that logic. This is finite-state-machine design (next chapter).
- Non-D flip-flops need an excitation table. For D flip-flops the input simply equals the desired next state.

Design with D Flip-Flops: 2-Bit Counter

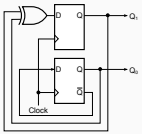


Q_1	Q_0	Q_1^+	Q_0^+	D_1	D_0
0	0	0	1	0	1
0	1	1	0	1	0
1	0	1	1	1	1
1	1	0	0	0	0

1. State diagram: arrows are unconditional.
2. State table: next state for each present state.
3. Flip-flop inputs: $D = Q^+$.
4. Equations by inspection:

$$D_1 = Q_1 \oplus Q_0 \qquad D_0 = \overline{Q_0}$$

5. Implement.



Example: Mod-5 Counter with D Flip-Flops

Q_2	Q_1	Q_0	Q_2^+	Q_1^+	Q_0^+
0	0	0	0	0	1
0	0	1	0	1	0
0	1	0	0	1	1
0	1	1	1	0	0
1	0	0	0	0	0
1	0	1	x	x	x
1	1	0	x	x	x
1	1	1	x	x	x

- Three unused states (101, 110, 111): their next states are don't cares.
- K-maps with the don't cares give:

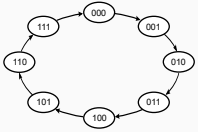
$$D_2 = Q_1 Q_0$$
$$D_1 = \overline{Q_2}\,\overline{Q_0} Q_1 + \overline{Q_2}\,\overline{Q_1} Q_0$$
$$D_0 = \overline{Q_2}\,\overline{Q_0}$$

Check self-correction

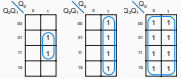
State 101 gives $D_2 D_1 D_0 = 000$: it returns to 000 next clock. Always verify this: don't-care simplification does not guarantee it.

Design with T Flip-Flops: Mod-8 Counter

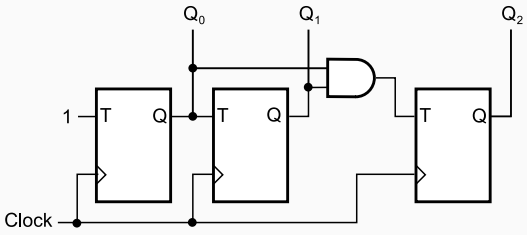
Q_2	Q_1	Q_0	Q_2^+	Q_1^+	Q_0^+	T_2	T_1	T_0
0	0	0	0	0	1	0	0	1
0	0	1	0	1	0	0	1	1
0	1	0	0	1	1	0	0	1
0	1	1	1	0	0	1	1	1
1	0	0	1	0	1	0	0	1
1	0	1	1	1	0	0	1	1
1	1	0	1	1	1	0	0	1
1	1	1	0	0	0	1	1	1



- A T input is 1 when the flip-flop must change.
- K-maps give $T_2 = Q_1Q_0$, $T_1 = Q_0$, $T_0 = 1$.



Mod-8 Counter Schematic and the General Rule



General rule for *n*-bit T-flip-flop up counters

$$T_i = Q_{i-1}Q_{i-2}\cdots Q_1Q_0, \quad T_0 = 1$$

Bit *i* toggles exactly when all lower bits are 1 (the ripple-carry condition).

A 4-bit counter needs $T_3 = Q_2Q_1Q_0$ with no fourth K-map. T flip-flops suit binary up counters: each T_i is a simple AND, unlike the D-flip-flop expressions.

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Back to the Opening Question

Blinking an LED once per second

The counter divides 50 000 000 Hz down to 1 Hz, so its modulus is 50 000 000. That needs 26 flip-flops and is not a power of two, so the counter must be truncated (design it with the modulo-*N* procedure). A ripple version would be far too slow at 50 MHz, so a synchronous design is the sensible choice.

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Summary

- An asynchronous (ripple) counter clocks each stage from the previous one: simple, but delay accumulates and limits speed.
- A synchronous counter clocks every flip-flop together: faster, with more logic.
- Modulo-N counters (N not a power of two), such as a decade counter, are designed with the synchronous design procedure; check unused states for self-correction.
- A counter divides frequency by its modulus: divide-by-N turns f Hz into f/N Hz.

Looking ahead

Counters give an *ordered* sequence of states. When the next state depends on inputs, we need a *finite state machine*: Chapters 13–15.